IDBI capital

Chemicals

Prices stay range bound

Summary

The month of November saw mixed chemical price movement: while MEG was down 9% MoM, Maleic Anhydride rose 6%. The growth in Ref gases also softened, as the refrigerant gases index grew by 4% MoM. As before the jump was supported by 5-6% jump in R410a and R134a. This was visible in the results of our coverage companies, NFIL and SRF, which posted not just strong results but also indicate a strong positive outlook in terms of ref-gas pricing.

Prices have remained more or less stable, with only small jumps, in our tracking universe on MoM basis. Stable prices are beneficial to the producers as well as the consumers as stability provides better future visibility and planning. Acetone prices saw a downfall of 8% which comes after a strong, 3-month long run. TDI prices also fell in step-wise manner culminating in a 5% drop in price on MoM basis. Toluene prices were up by 5% this month impacting prominent consumers such as Aarti Industries. Benzene prices broke out of its price decline and exhibited an uptick of 4% MoM.

On the Ref-gases front, we find the prices on a secular up-trend for the last one year, with the R22 commanding premium pricing due to the Montreal Convention led production clamp-downs. R32, the replacement for R22 has also witnessed rising pricing, albeit, at an average discount of 15% compared to R22. All the Ref-Gases exhibited upward pricing trajectory on MoM basis.

Valuation snapshot

Companies	Reco	Mkt Cap Rs bn	CMP (Rs)	TP (Rs)	*Upside (%)*	PER (x) FY26E	PER (x) FY27E
SRF	**BUY**	868	2,929	3,517	*20.1*	44.7	38.5
Neogen Chem.	**BUY**	30	1,125	2,001	*77.9*	64.4	71.2
Navin Fluorine	**BUY**	294	5,735	6,001	*4.6*	49.2	40.8
Acutaas	**BUY**	150	1,837	2,141	*16.5*	57.2	43.0
Clean Science	**BUY**	97	913	1,201	*31.5*	34.6	30.1

Source: IDBI Capital Research

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While the chemical prices have been in an elongated downward trajectory post the COVID highs, there could be some consolidation going ahead in the short run. CRDMO companies are witnessing significant tailwinds in terms of growth. Companies which are moving higher up the value chain in terms of scale and complexity stand to benefit immensely from a longer term perspective. Acutaas remains one of our preferred names on the back of rich expertise in manufacturing of Advanced Pharma Intermediates and upcoming capex ramp up of the Ankleshwar unit. We are also positive on Neogen Chemicals owing to its deep bromination expertise and strong first mover advantage into battery chemicals. We also prefer Clean Science owing to its impressive HALS scale-up and better than expected realizations going forward.

Key Highlights

- **Macro Scenario:** The ever and inexplicably changing tariff scenario has led to pause in investments by end user industries, until more clarity emerges. This is bound to exert a downward pressure on prices. Volatility in oil prices, which is a major raw material for a large majority of chemicals, could further exacerbate the slowdown in capex.
- **Outlook**: We believe that commodity chemicals segment could remain range bound from the current levels owing to steady domestic demand. Companies that are delivering value added products and moving higher up the value chain in terms of scale and complexity will fare better as compared to pure commodity plays in the long term.

Exhibit 1: Pricing Snapshot

Chemical	Dec-2025	Dec-2024	YoY (Change)	Nov-2025	MoM (Change)	Peak	Drawdown from Peak
Benzene	74	92	-20%	71	4%	120	-38%
Aniline	130	156	-17%	129	1%	254	-49%
Heavy Soda Ash	28	38	-26%	28	0%	55	-49%
Toluene	96	81	19%	91	5%	155	-38%
Phthalic Anhydride	87	94	-7%	90	-3%	134	-35%
Monoethylene Glycol (MEG)	53	64	-17%	58	-9%	91	-42%
Phenol	107	111	-4%	107	0%	166	-36%
Acetone	67	77	-13%	73	-8%	130	-48%
Isopropyl Alcohol (IPA)	86	107	-20%	93	-8%	155	-45%
Acetonitrile	133	130	2%	140	-5%	330	-60%
Acetic Acid	47	52	-9%	50	-6%	160	-71%
Caustic Soda Lye	36	42	-13%	38	-4%	72	-50%
Ethyl Acetate	74	74	0%	74	0%	140	-47%
Toluene Diisocyanate (TDI)	178	214	-17%	187	-5%	300	-41%
Maleic Anhydride	86	92	-6%	81	6%	174	-51%
Methanol	39	34	15%	42	-8%	54	-29%
Vinyl Acetate Monomer (VAM)	85	79	8%	88	-3%	231	-63%
Acrylic Acid	100	95	5%	96	4%	290	-66%
LDPE	112	118	-5%	114	-2%	140	-20%
HDPE	92	94	-2%	94	-2%	138	-33%
R22	765	610	25%	750	2%	810	-6%
R134a	670	435	54%	630	6%	795	-16%
R32	645	510	26%	630	2%	765	-16%
R410a	685	485	41%	650	5%	710	-4%
Ref Gas Index	144	107	35%	139	4%	161	-10%

Source: Indianpetrochem, Change % based on month end prices, Peak Price =Max (From Jan-2021 to current date)

Exhibit 2: Brief Profile

Chemicals	Indian Manufacturer	Major Consumer
Benzene	BPCL, RIL, IOCL, ONGC	Aarti Inds, Apcotex, CFS, NFIL, Vinati, Deepak Nitrite, Valiant Org, Jyothy Labs
Aniline	GNFC, HOCL	Aarti Ind, Atul Ltd, Aurobindo, Bayer, Monsanto, UPL, BASF, Deepak Nitrite, Nocil, Valiant Org, Bodal, Bhageria, Kiri
Soda Ash	Tata Chem, GHCL, DCW, GFL	Deepak Nitrite
Toluene	Reliance, BPCL, Indian Oil	Aarti, NFIL, Vinati, Deepak Nitrite
Phthalic Anhydride	Thirumalai Chem, IGPL	
Mono Ethylene Glycol	RIL, India Glycols, IOCL	
Phenol	Deepak Phenolics, Hindustan Organics	
Acetone	Deepak Phenolics, SI Group	GSFC, ITC, Berger, Shalimar, Torrent Pharma, Sun Pharma, Asian Paints, Kansai Nerolac, Pfizer, NFIL
Iso Propyl Alcohol (IPA)	Deepak Nitrite, Deepak Fertilisers & Petrochemicals	
Acetonitrile	Alkyl amines, Balaji amines, Deepak Novochem	
Acetic acid	GNFC	Reliance, IOCL, Apcotex, SRF, Deepak Nitrite, Laxmi Org.
Caustic soda	Grasim, DCM Shriram, GACL, Nalco, RIL, DCW, TGV Sraac	Arvind Mills, Deepak Nitrite, GNFC, GSFC, IOC, Meghmani Organics, Nirma, NALCO, HUL, UPL
Ethyl Acetate	GNFC, Jubilant Ingrevia, Laxmi Organics	
TDI	BASF, GNFC	
High-Density Polyethylene (HDPE)	Reliance, ONGC, GAIL	
Low-Density Polyethylene (LDPE)	Reliance	
Maleic Anhydride	Thirumalai Chem, IGPL	
Methanol	RCF, NFL, IOCL, Deepak Fertilizers, GNFC, GSFC	Alkyl Amines, Balaji Amines, Aarti, CFS, NFIL, SRF, Vinati
PAN (Phthalic Anhydride)	Thirumalai Chem, IGPL	
Acrylic Acid	BPCL, IOCL, BASF, GSFC	Apcotex, Black Rose, Balmer Lawrie, Fineotex

Source: Company; IDBI Capital Research

Refrigerant Gases Index

Our Ref-gas index is an equal weighted index, comprised of R22, R134a, R32 and R410a.

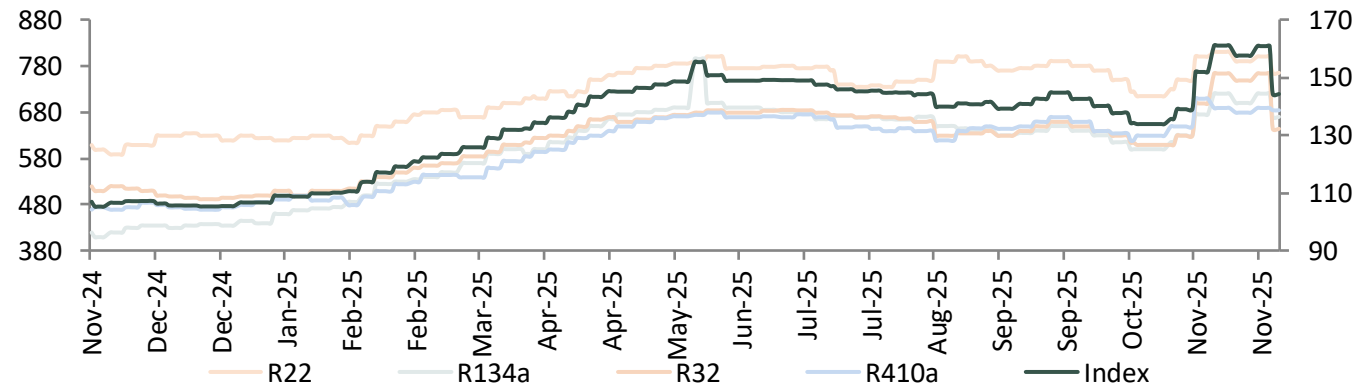
R22: A legacy refrigerant HCFC gas, R22 is getting phased out due to its ozone depleting properties. With a GWP of ~1810, the gas was used in legacy AC units and refrigerators. The Montreal Protocol, led to the phase out on R12 (Ozone Depletion Potential of 1, viz R22's ODP of 0.05); and was later expanded to phase out of R22. The phase out plan entails a reduction by 67.5% by 2025, 97.5% by 2030 and complete replacement by 2040. Due to no new production, the price of R22 have been on a secular uptrend.

R134a: This again is a legacy CFC, aimed at replacing R12. It is used in automobile ACs, chillers and medium temperature refrigerators. It has a lower efficiency as well GWP than R22. This gas is under restriction of EU/F-gas norms.

R32: A pure refrigerant, with a much lower GWP of ~675 (almost a third of R22's ~1810) and good efficiency, R32 is a HFC molecule. The lack of the Chlorine molecule contributes to the depressed GWP and the lowered ozone layer depletion. Due to this, R32 has become the preferred choice for split ACs and VRFs, especially in Asia, with players such as Panasonic, Daikin, LG etc. pushing for its use. The only drawback is the slightly inflammable nature of the gas.

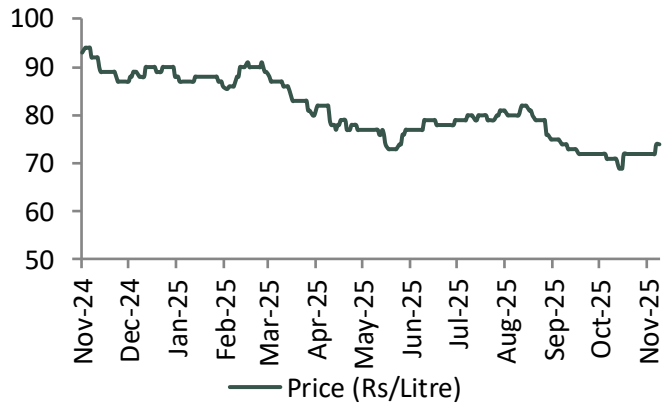
R410a: This is a blend refrigerant, widely used in commercial ACs, and heat pumps. The blend consists of R32 and R125, 50:50. The blend also faces threat from R32 due to its higher GWP.

Exhibit 3: Ref-gas Index up by 4% MoM



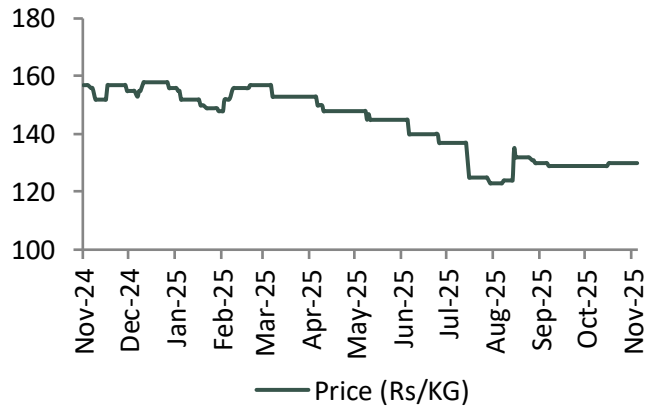
Source: IDBI Capital, Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 4: Benzene Prices up by 4% MoM



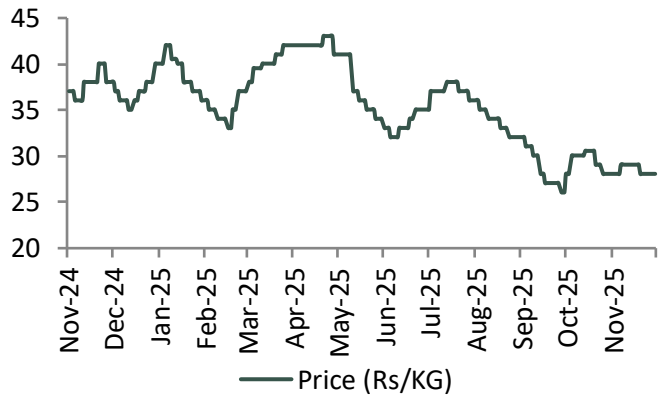
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 5: Aniline Prices up by 1% MoM



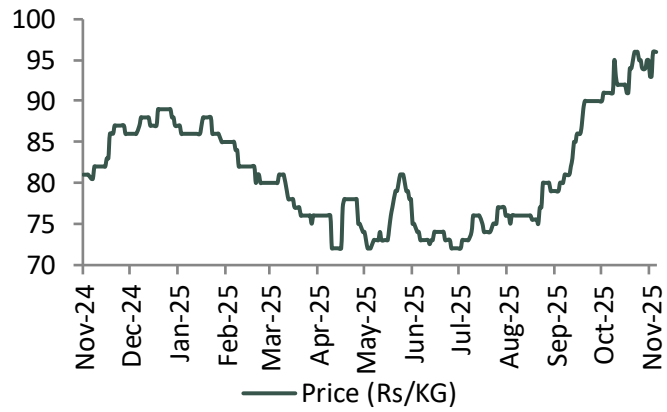
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 6: Heavy Soda Ash flat MoM



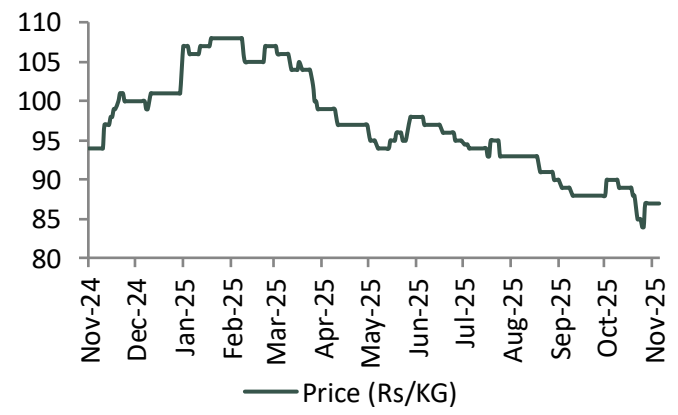
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 7: Toluene Prices up by 5% MoM



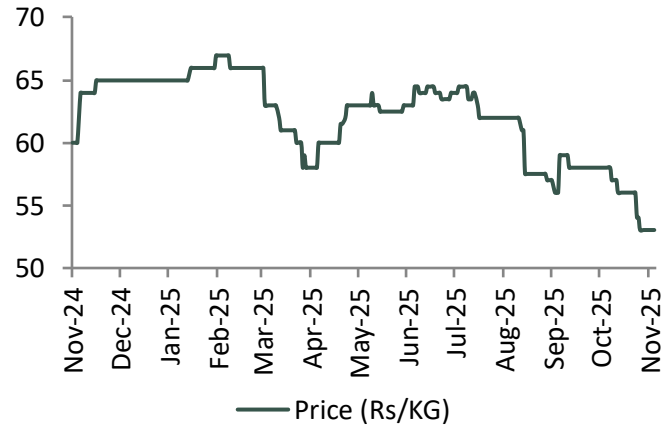
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 8: Phthalic Anhydride down by 3% MoM



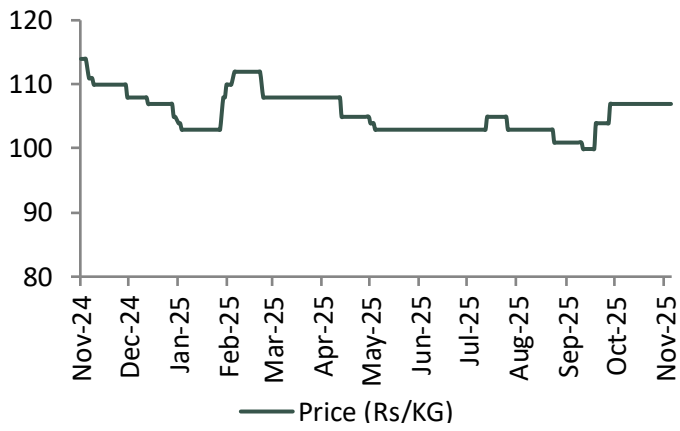
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 9: Monoethylene Glycol down by 9% MoM



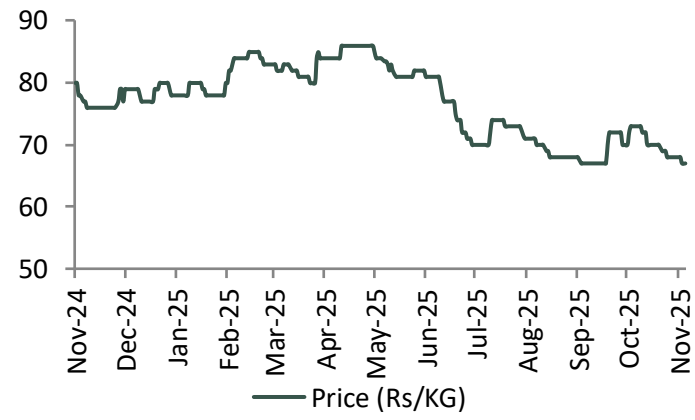
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 10: Phenol Prices flat MoM



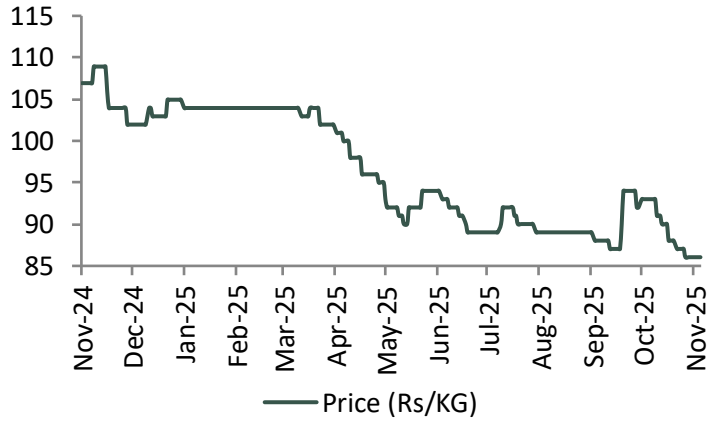
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 11: Acetone Prices down by 8% MoM



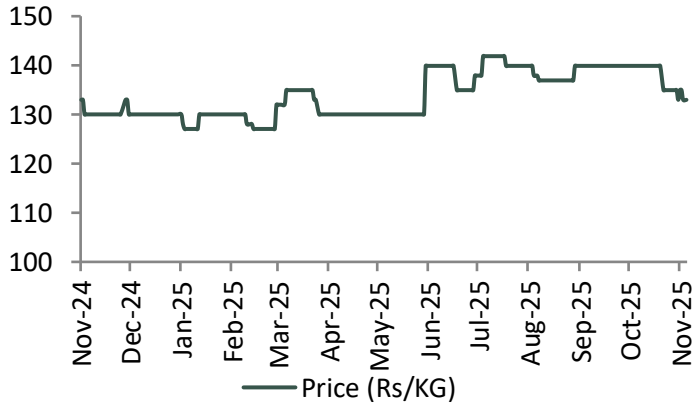
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 12: Isopropyl Alcohol Prices down 8% MoM



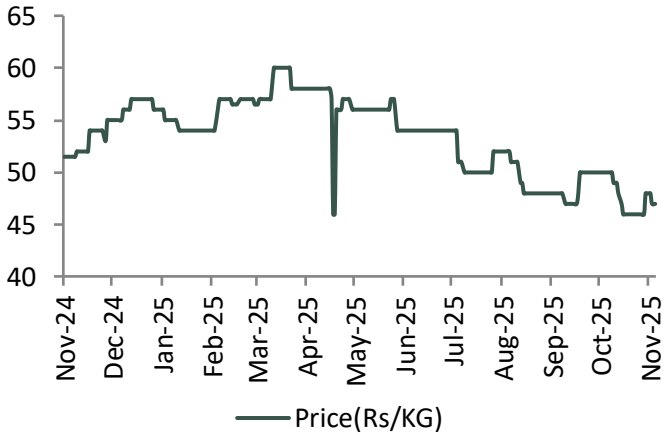
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 13: Acetonitrile Prices down by 5% MoM



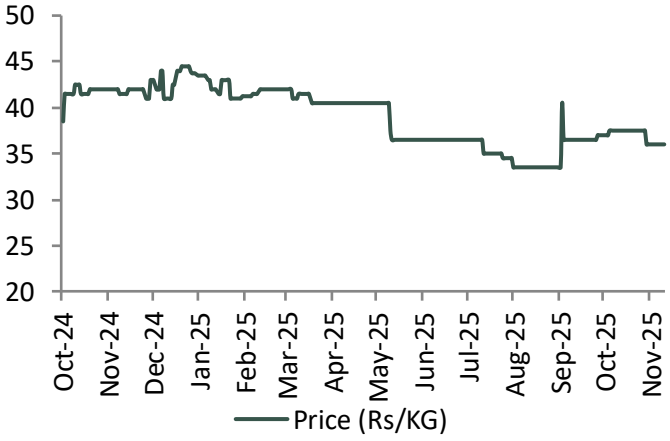
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 14: Acetic Acid Prices down by 6% MoM



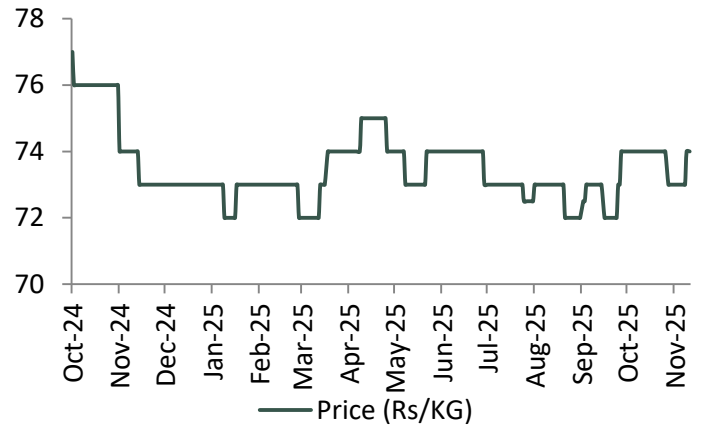
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 15: Caustic Soda Prices down by 4% MoM



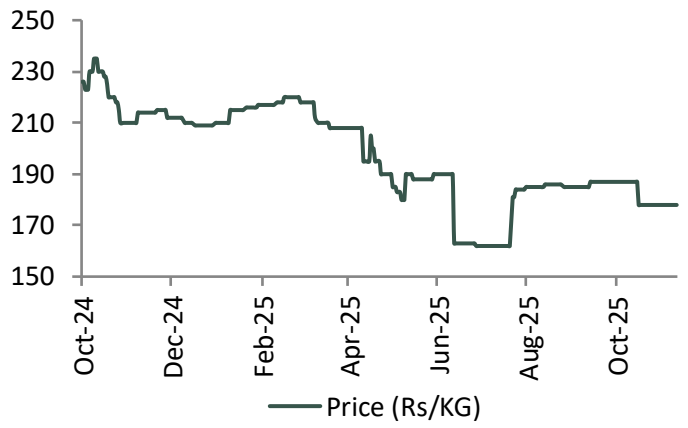
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 16: Ethyl Acetate Prices flat MoM



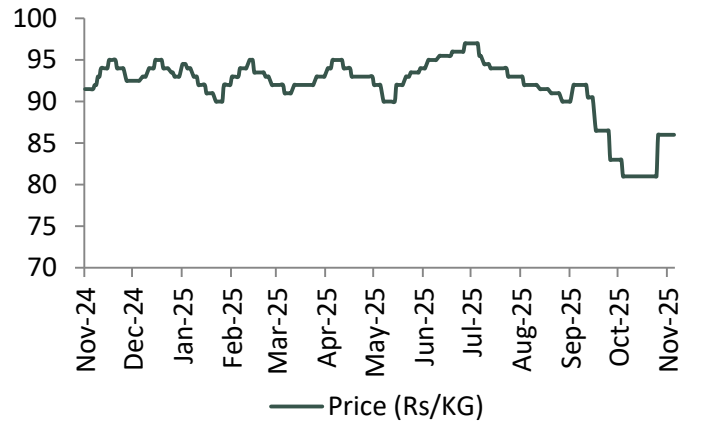
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 17: Toluene Diisocyanate Prices down by 5% MoM



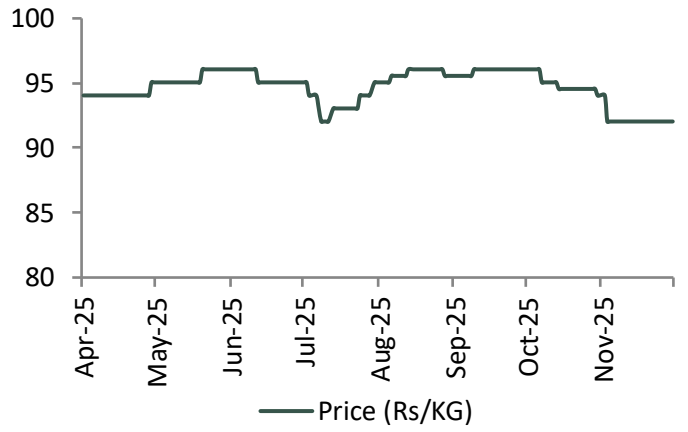
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 18: Maleic Anhydride up by 6% MoM



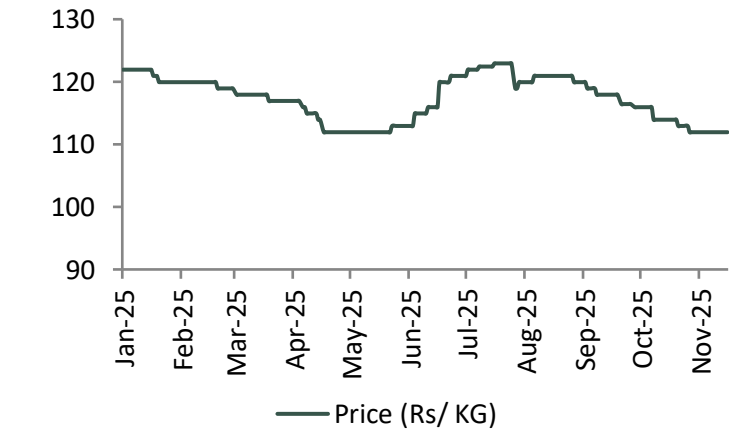
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 19: HDPE Prices down by 2% MoM



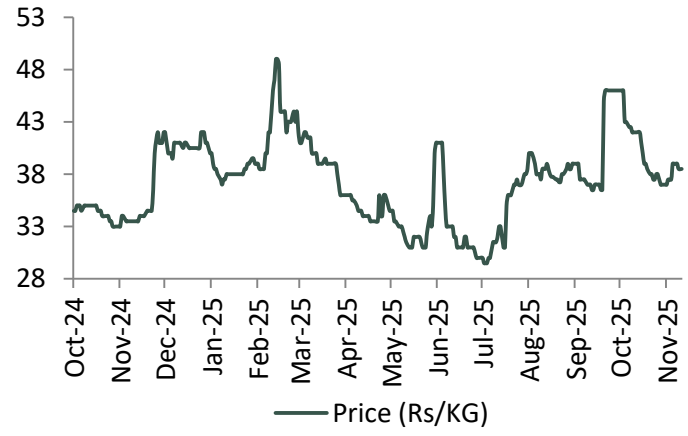
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 20: LDPE down by 2% MoM



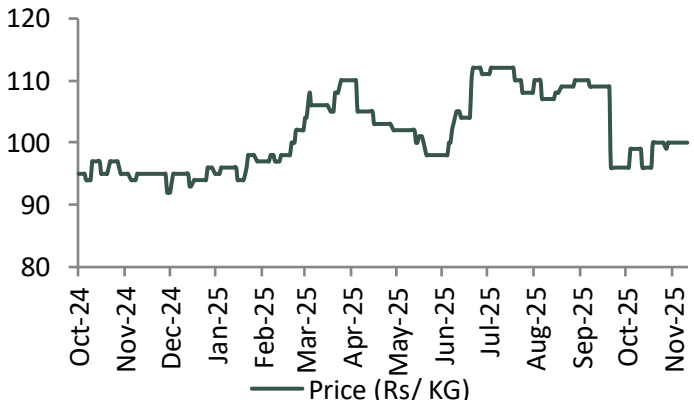
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 21: Methanol Prices down by 8% MoM



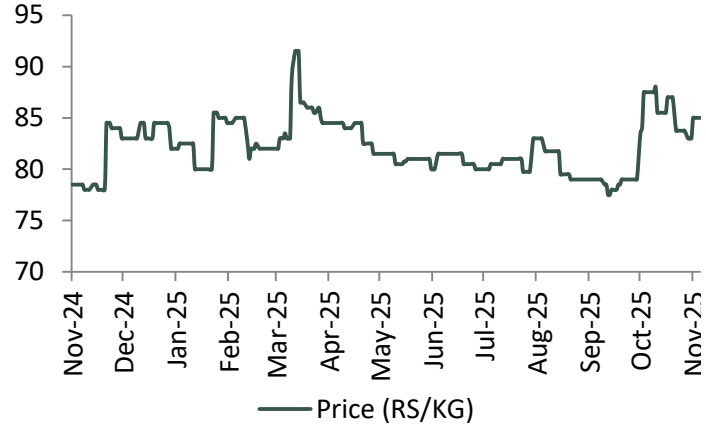
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 22: Acrylic Acid up by 4% MoM



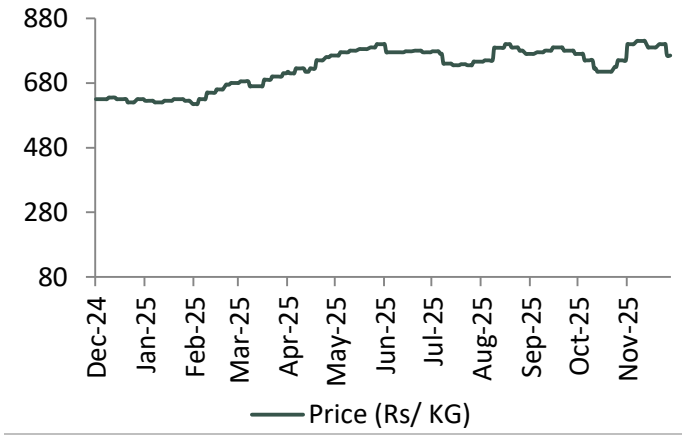
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 23: VAM Prices down by 3% MoM



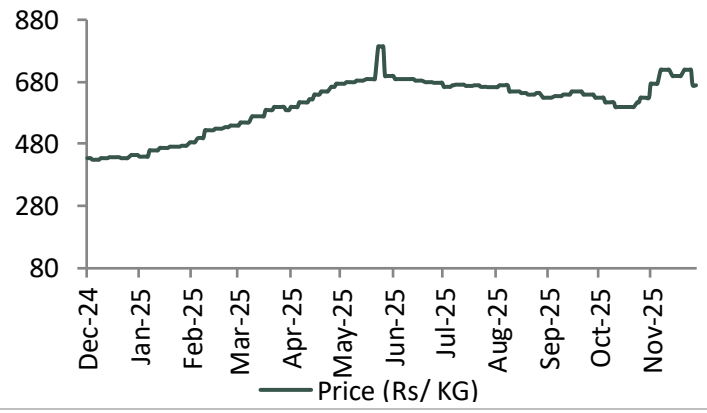
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 24: R22 up by 2% MoM



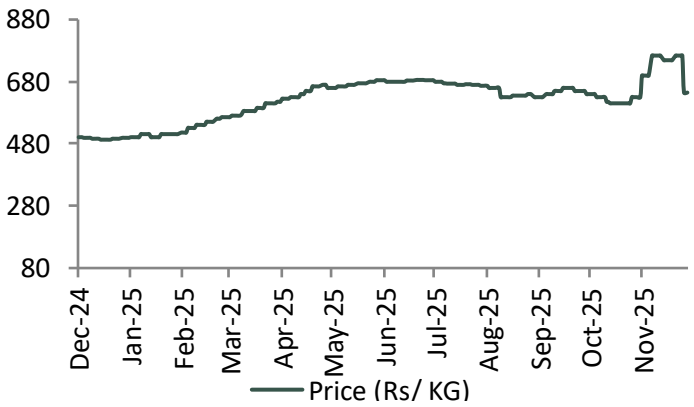
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 25: R134a Prices up by 6% MoM



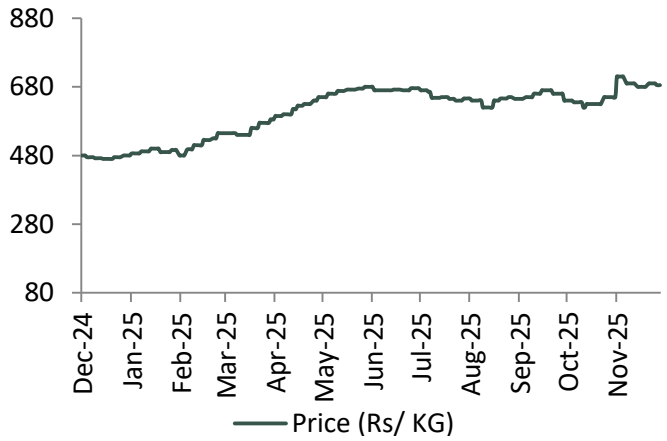
Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 26: R32 up by 2% MoM



Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 27: R410a Prices up by 5% MoM



Source: Indianpetrochem

Exhibit 28: Sectoral Stock Performance

	Mkt Cap	Performance (%)				Relative to Index (%)			
	Rs bn	1M	12M	3 Year	5 Year	1M	12M	3 Year	5 Year
SRF	864	-1%	29%	23%	179%	-3%	20%	-19%	79%
Deepak Nitrite	213	-10%	-43%	-29%	86%	-12%	-52%	-71%	-15%
Gujarat Fluorochemicals	377	-8%	-13%	5%	478%	-11%	-22%	-37%	377%
Aarti Industries	138	0%	-15%	-42%	-26%	-2%	-24%	-84%	-127%
Navin Fluorine International	297	2%	65%	35%	119%	0%	56%	-7%	18%
Fine Organics	135	-1%	-15%	-27%	68%	-3%	-24%	-69%	-33%
Clean Science	97	-10%	-29%	-41%	-	-12%	-38%	-83%	-
Aether Industries	117	17%	8%	-3%	-	15%	-2%	-45%	-
Alkyl Amines	86	-9%	-14%	-40%	3%	-12%	-23%	-81%	-98%
GNFC	73	-1%	-22%	-16%	132%	-3%	-31%	-57%	31%
Galaxy Surfactants	72	-9%	-28%	-26%	7%	-12%	-37%	-68%	-94%
Anupam Rasayan	138	13%	66%	69%	-	11%	56%	27%	-
Jubilant Ingrevia	114	4%	-9%	35%	-	1%	-18%	-6%	-
Balaji Amines	38	-18%	-44%	-60%	14%	-20%	-53%	-101%	-87%
Laxmi Organics	51	-7%	-30%	-41%	-	-9%	-39%	-83%	-
Gujarat Alkalies and Chemicals	39	-7%	-32%	-33%	57%	-9%	-41%	-75%	-43%
GHCL	55	-10%	-4%	5%	220%	-13%	-13%	-37%	119%
Ami Organics	150	6%	71%	276%	-	4%	62%	234%	-
Neogen Chemicals	30	-21%	-46%	-11%	66%	-24%	-55%	-52%	-35%
I G Petrochemicals	12	-7%	-37%	-28%	-18%	-9%	-46%	-70%	-119%

Source: Bloomberg, IDBI Capital Research

JASON SOANS

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